

Ethnographic research

What this tool produces · *Thick descriptions of actual human behaviors, coping mechanisms, and physical appropriations of space that challenge top-down assumptions.*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Dimensions

Social / User

Heritage

Spatial

Preparing the workshop · *Ethnographic research*

G1 · Proof of Impact

Why this tool matters

Learning to look at the city from the eye level of the most vulnerable; capturing the silent intelligence and survival strategies of bodies navigating the urban landscape.

Evidence we produce

Thick descriptions of actual human behaviors, coping mechanisms, and physical appropriations of space that challenge top-down assumptions.

Duration & Material

Duration · Several days to a few weeks of immersion

Material · Field journal, camera, behavioral mapping grids, time/space maps

Reference case

A Rapid Ethnographic Assessment Procedure (REAP) was used by the US National Park Service at Jacob Riis Park. It revealed that costly historic restorations meant nothing to the actual new users (recent immigrants), who only wanted shade for family picnics, radically altering the design priorities and proving that observing actual behavior is vital for culturally relevant spatial planning.

Suggested agenda · Brief (10 min) > Method walk-through (15 min) > Animation canvas (60-90 min) > Harvest (20 min)

Field journal · silent observation

Duration
Several days to a few weeks of immersion

Date · ____ · **Place** · ____ · **Time slot** · ____

Postures

*how bodies hold themselves
standing, leaning, hiding...*

Appropriations

*how people make space their own
furniture, signs, traces*

Flows

*how movement runs
paths, bottlenecks, detours*

Verbatim

*fragments overheard
words, tones, exchanges*

Time × space matrix

Zone	Morning	Midday	Afternoon	Evening
Centre				
Edges				
Hidden corners				

Harvesting our *learnings*

After running the canvas, capture three layers of insight.

What inspires me

Stand-out signals, surprising stories, ideas to remember

How to apply it here

Concrete adaptations to our context, our team, our constraints

What we need to be autonomous

Skills, allies, resources, decisions still to secure

Each participant fills a copy. Then debrief together to surface patterns and next steps.